utmost respect. Most of the guys call him ‘Gools’, but I’m sticking with the name Gary Kirsten gave him – ‘Ledge’.

Because Goolam Rajah *is* a legend.

Allan Donald

I played with Allan from 1996 to 2003, and every time we got together, we had at least five beers! I could never understand how this man could drink so much and then still bowl so well the next day. He’d have a bottle of wine with his supper, and sometimes drink four beers in a team meeting. Ja, Allan Donald … he loves his beer. Allan’s got his own 50-litre keg at home, which was a present from Castle Lager.

On our first full tour of the West Indies in 2001, Allan and I drank *every day*. Put it this way, I decided that every time he drank, I’d have a drink with him … which, of course, was a mistake. Allan is phenomenal and handles his drink better than anybody else I know. When we had a day off on the tour, or after we’d finished a match, we’d have a couple of pots. You’d be on, like, your sixth or seventh beer and Allan would be on his tenth. He’d still be behaving like nothing was happening. You’re getting slaughtered and he’s going, ‘Are you okay? What’s going on?’

The one time I did see Allan pissed, though, was on a tour. We were with a mutual friend of ours and drinking whisky. Allan could put the beers away – and stay stick thin, I never knew how he managed that – but he couldn’t quite handle spirits with the same aplomb.

I reckon Allan learnt to drink in the years he played county cricket. I mean, he went over to Warwickshire when he was, like, 18 or 19. And anybody who goes to play in England year after year is going to learn how to drink.

I’m only telling you about the drinking because I’m proud to have played with Allan and to have known him. The drinking is just a very small part of Allan. As a cricketer, I’ve always regarded him as a total professional. And he’s just a champion guy, you know … a very, very nice guy. I always felt very close to him and could talk to him about anything.

Allan actually kicked off my wristwatch fetish too. Not that he kicked off my drinking fetish – I reckon I did that on my own – but he used to buy a pair of golf shoes on every Proteas tour. Every time, he had to get at least one pair. So I started buying watches on tour, and I bought my first TAG